

# PLAYWRITING



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Book: Playwriting (Garcia)

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# TABLE OF CONTENTS

[Licensing](#)

## 1: Chapters

- [1.1: Playwriting](#)
- [1.2: The Steps of the Writing Process](#)
- [1.3: The Idea Store](#)
- [1.4: Research](#)
- [1.5: Theme](#)
- [1.6: Conflict](#)
- [1.7: Types of Story](#)
- [1.8: Setting](#)
- [1.9: Character and Story Archetypes](#)
- [1.10: Plot](#)
- [1.11: Dialogue](#)
- [1.12: Creating Characters](#)
- [1.13: Scene](#)
- [1.14: Crafting the Plot](#)
- [1.15: The Process](#)
- [1.16: Writing Exercises](#)

[Index](#)

[Detailed Licensing](#)

## Licensing

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*A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).*

## CHAPTER OVERVIEW

### 1: Chapters

- [1.1: Playwriting](#)
- [1.2: The Steps of the Writing Process](#)
- [1.3: The Idea Store](#)
- [1.4: Research](#)
- [1.5: Theme](#)
- [1.6: Conflict](#)
- [1.7: Types of Story](#)
- [1.8: Setting](#)
- [1.9: Character and Story Archetypes](#)
- [1.10: Plot](#)
- [1.11: Dialogue](#)
- [1.12: Creating Characters](#)
- [1.13: Scene](#)
- [1.14: Crafting the Plot](#)
- [1.15: The Process](#)
- [1.16: Writing Exercises](#)

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## 1.1: Playwriting

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Playwriting is a terrifying and exhilarating endeavor and it is the basis of dramatic art. The audience came to hear a story, escape from their lives and problems, and be transformed by experiencing the struggles of another individual. The playwright is the creator of worlds, deity of conflict, and messenger of the essential truths human beings need to hear over and over throughout their lives. However, like with all things, with great power comes great responsibility.

Playwrights are responsible for creating the entire story of the play, creating the world, the characters, the conflict, and making sure that the story builds in tension to a degree that it captivates the audience. But how do you know if the play is good? You don't. You put your heart and soul into the project, stress over its reception and in the end you watch it with the audience and see what works and what does not. If you want to be a playwright you have to be brave and you have to be fearless because you are constantly handing over your child to someone else and hoping for the best. Along the process you are going to learn hard lessons and be humiliated, but at the same time when an audience laughs at your jokes or is captivated by your characters you will feel a sense of fulfillment that will be unmatched. When you start out you will be bad. Everyone is bad at first, but then as you learn how to structure stories and how to develop your own voice and perspective you will turn into the artist you were meant to be. An artist creates their masterpiece at the end of their career because each work leading up to it was, at a time, that artist's masterpiece. Make it your mission to always strive to be better and you will have a career you will be proud of.

New work is the life blood of theater and theater is always in need of new ideas and perspectives. Nobody thinks like you do and because of that we want to hear your story. I have been teaching playwriting for over ten years and have developed, or helped over 150 ten minute plays and 12 full-length plays from scratch, many of which have won awards. In that time I have been continuously impressed by the talent and ideas of my students, but it is their hard work that has allowed each project to become successful. Hard work will always beat talent because talented people are often lazy. However, if you are talented and hardworking then you will be unstoppable.

This book is a resource designed to help guide you through the essential components of a play and is designed to serve as a guide to helping you develop a process for your writing that has been proven over time to be successful. These lessons are garnered from many books, interviews, classes, and life lessons on playwriting and story development.

A play is a story told through dialogue and action. A play also poses a difficult problem that the characters or heroes try to solve over the course of the narrative. At the end of the journey the hero has been transformed and has learned something about themselves that is one of life's essential truths. Stories are the way humans have protected and transferred the essential truths of our species and it is why stories are the primary way humans communicate with each other. As a playwright you are a world builder as well as a guardian and mouthpiece for the essential truths. I hope that on your journey you find this book helpful and I look forward to one day seeing your plays.

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## 1.2: The Steps of the Writing Process

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- **Step 1:** Get an idea or concept for your story
  - **Step 2:** Research
  - **Step 3:** Develop a theme for your story
  - **Step 4:** Decide on a story type and conflict for your story
  - **Step 5:** Select a Setting
  - **Step 6:** Develop Characters based around the conflict and assign them to archetypes
  - **Step 7:** Create an Inciting Incident and Climax for your story
  - **Step 8:** Structure the plot and create an outline
  - **Step 9:** Break plot into scenes and begin writing
  - **Step 10:** Write
  - **Step 11:** Read and Revise
  - **Step 12:** Workshop through readings with performers
  - **Step 13:** Put it up in front of an audience
  - **Step 14:** Revise
  - **Step 15:** Complete the project and move on to your next play.
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## 1.3: The Idea Store

Some writers are idea factories and can look almost anywhere and find a new twist on a story or situation that is worth watching, but what do you do when you cannot find an idea? That is easy, you go to the Idea Store. The Idea Store is a series of exercises that are designed to get your synapses firing and your creative juices flowing. There will always be times where you are at a loss of ideas and so the Idea Store was created to help you get started on a concept for your story.

### Story Mash-ups

People love stories but they really love when you can take a story they already know and twist it in such a way that it makes them reevaluate the story they already loved. A story mash-up is where you take a story or Myth that you know very well and mash it or combine it with a new genre, perspective, or additional story.

- Step 1:
  - For this exercise you will need to make a list of Genres. Write down as many as you can.
- Step 2:
  - Write down a list of the titles of your favorite stories. Make sure that you vary them in theme and content. For example, make a list of Fairy Tales, Myths, Contemporary plays, Family Stories, Books, etc.
- Step 3:
  - Cut each individual Genre out and place it in a bowl/ box/ hat/ etc. Cut out your favorite story titles and place them in a separate bowl .
- Step 4:
  - Pick a sheet of paper from each bowl look at the combination. See if you can write a play about it. If the combination is too similar to the original story pick from the bowl again.

### Twisting the Narrative

Choose a play or story and see if you can examine the story from another character's perspective. Let's say you have the story of Rapunzel, but you think why would a mother lock her child up in a tower far away? What if Rapunzel was a vampire and or violent psychopath that the queen removed for the safety of the kingdom. How would that change the story? One incredible example is the play Wicked. The play takes the story of The Wizard of Oz and turns it on its head and forces the audience to identify with the villain and audiences could not have been more delighted.

- Step 1:
  - Write down the title of a famous story or a story you know very well.
- Step 2:
  - Look at the basic plot elements of the story and see if you can look at the story from a new perspective. Ask yourself why the events of the story would have logically taken place.
- Step 3:
  - See where your thoughts take you.

### Displacing or Replacing a Character

As a playwright you need to study people. We all have unique people around us and at the very least you have unique characters from stories that you love. This exercise is about distilling people down to characters, and placing those characters in unusual situations in order to maximize the conflict and entertainment of a story. The following exercise can be done with people you know, characters you read about, or by going out and studying people in your community.

- Step 1:
  - Go to a public place, sit down, and observe the people around you.
- Step 2:
  - When you spot someone interesting write down notes about their appearance and behavior. What makes them distinct?
- Step 3

- Now create a backstory about them and try to see if you can create a reason for why they are the way they are.
- Step 4
  - Ask yourself what situation could that character be placed in that would cause the most disruption to both the character and the status quo.

## Headlines

Some of the most interesting stories come from news headlines you read. Each day there are compelling stories that you want to learn more about and this could be your opportunity. I remember years ago reading a story about a police officer in Oakland that wrote a letter to his department confessing his involvement in a sex ring involving other members on the force and a underage girl who was a family member of a fellow cop. The officer wrote the letter, submitted it, and took his own life. This story still haunts me and maybe one day it will become a play, but there are so many questions that were raised and the entire police force was forced to change as a result. In addition, each year planes and people vanish into thin air or unlikely heroes emerge in times of need. Look to your news feeds for inspiration. As you research make sure to get permission from people if you actually use their lives.

- Step 1:
  - Look at a news headline that catches your eye and research the story around it.
- Step 2:
  - Ask yourself, what other stories could be told from this story? Whose perspective is the most interesting? What questions do I want to explore and or answer?
- Step 3
  - Start writing.

## Music, Props, and Art

Often you will find that your best ideas come from art and objects that you see or hear. Find music that transports you to another world, find art that terrifies you or draws you in, or look for objects or props that tell a story.

One person brought in a pocket watch to class one day. Everyone in the class was drawn to it, and it had something about it that was unsettling. A member of the class then said “what if something supernatural had that watch.” Then another person built off of that idea and said “What if that person was at a casino.” Then the idea formed for everyone that we could have a demon run a casino, get people to bet their souls and when they lost, their souls were stored in the watch. With that idea, we wrote the play Snare.

- Step 1:
  - Go to an art gallery, museum, antique store, pawn shop, prop storage, or listen to music. Choose a piece that draws you in and ask yourself why.
- Step 2:
  - Ask yourself, what stories could be told from this art/ object/ music? Whose perspective is the most interesting? What questions do I want to explore and or answer?
- Step 3
  - Start writing.

## Word Dump

Sometimes you are going to have a really good idea in your head that has been brewing for some time. A word dump is where you sit down and write down every idea you have in a sort of idea dump from your brain to the page. Write down every idea, plot point, and character that you have thought of and then examine your ideas once they are out of your head and in front of you.

- Step 1:
  - Sit down. Write down every idea connected to the story/ idea/ narrative down on paper
- Step 2:

- Ask yourself, what fits and what doesn't. Then ask yourself how you could structure the ideas so that they built in intensity and reached a climax. Then place them in an order. Examine it. Rearrange the ideas until you are happy with the progression.
- Step 3
  - Start writing.

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## 1.4: Research

Your level research is dependant upon the story you are telling. Some projects like biographies or historical dramas require vast amounts of research, while others require very little because you are creating an original world. You also can choose where to add research into your process, for some projects it may be in the beginning as you are gathering ideas and other times it may be once you have developed characters and have identified a setting and conflict. You want to research as much as you can about the world and characters of your play, however do not get lost in research and forget that research is meaningless if it never results in a play.

### When looking for Ideas

When you first begin the process of writing you will go through one of two stages. Stage one is I have too many ideas. Stage two is I have no ideas at all. Regardless of which stage you begin your journey in, rest assured that you will find something that inspires you. It may be a headline, a product, a phrase, a song...anything and from that inspiration you will begin developing your world. Once you have a location, profession, event, or general idea of the subject matter of your play you can begin your research. Start by looking at the world you wish to inhabit for your play. Then ask yourself where you can find materials to learn about this world. The world should be interesting to you so that you can attack your research and have fun while you are exploring. Learn everything you can and as you learn you will find that you begin discovering additional questions. Follow the trail of questions and see where it leads you. Once you feel that you have become familiar with the world, use your research to inform your characters and plot. Only use research that helps the plot and tells the story. Be willing to let fun facts go, because your audience only cares about the story and your research was there to reinforce the story's authenticity.

### Interviews

One incredibly helpful research tool is to interview people with experience in the subject matter or world of your play. If you simply tell people that you are researching information for a play or story you will be amazed at how much people are willing to help. Interview as many people as you can. When you interview, LISTEN. Remember you are there to gain knowledge from their experience. You can take notes or record the interview. Your rule should be to Listen, Listen, Listen, then Ask strategic questions.

#### Playwriting Activity 1

- Make a list of ideas that you are interested in writing a play about.
- Choose one idea and find 5 sources to learn about for your story.
- Find a friend or partner and see if they can help you come up with any additional sources.
- Go research and take notes.

#### Playwriting Activity 2

- Choose an environment. Research that environment and its inhabitants.
- Find someone from that location and interview them. Listen, listen, listen, and then ask strategic questions. At the end of the interview, ask "Tell me something I don't know about."
- From your research identify 5 potential conflicts that could arise from your environment and research.

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## 1.5: Theme

A theme is an idea, a simple, clear, and powerful idea. Every story you have ever been told was created to teach you something. The more powerful and life changing the lesson, the more sacred the story. Human beings are incredible entities that extract meaning from stories that are not true. It is this ability that has allowed the arts and creativity to thrive. If your story has no theme then it has no lesson and will leave your audience's minds faster than it entered. If you are going to spend months or years of your life on a story shouldn't it be important? Human beings not only extract lessons from stories, but often base our existence on them. One of my favorite quotes was from a Neil Gaiman book (which he attributed to another writer and later said he made up). "Stories are important not because they teach us that dragons are real, but that they can be defeated,"

The theme is the heartbeat/ soul/ central message of the story. The theme is power statement in which the entire imaginary world of the play was created in order to deliver. The theme is vital because it will help guide how you develop the characters and their objectives and will also guide how the production is presented. Each character will have a relationship to this theme and this will determine his/her actions. Think of the theme as the glue or force that connects all of the souls that both view and present the production. When starting a play and identifying your theme ask yourself why do you need to tell the story? Why should the audience watch? What makes this story special? Once you have written these ideas down see if you can summarize or synthesize it in one sentence.

### Playwriting Activity 1: Finding Themes in popular films

- Pick 2 films and identify the Theme. What makes that theme essential to the film? How do the characters reflect that theme?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a theme you can agree on

### Playwriting Activity 2: Finding Themes in popular plays

- Pick 2 plays and identify the theme. What makes the theme essential? How do the characters reflect that theme?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a theme you can agree on.

### Playwriting Activity 3: Finding Your Themes

- Write down the core mottos, themes, slogans, rules, or guiding principles that have had the deepest impact within your life.
- Pick 2 of the most important. Once selected, find a friend or partner and share your ideas.
- See how your partner responds to the themes. Discuss.

### Playwriting Activity 4: Finding themes Through External Sources

- Look around you and find ideas, concepts, or current events that could inspire you to write a play about.
- Pick 2 of the scenarios/stories/events. Once the event is selected, choose the theme or message you wish to convey through each of these events.
- Find a friend or partner and share your ideas.

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## 1.6: Conflict

Conflict is the primary ingredient of drama and without it drama ceases to exist. Conflict is when two opposing forces collide. David and Goliath, Harry Potter and Voldemort, You and Your Future are all examples of opposing forces and these forces meet within the battlefield of story. Stories were invented to help us make sense of the world and find our place in it, and the world is full of conflict. Stories are how our ancestors taught the children in the tribe how to hunt, gather, be part of the community and find their way in life. The power of story still resonates with us today. We all have goals and needs and must navigate obstacles in order to achieve them. In fact you cannot exist without encountering conflict constantly throughout your day. In stories, the greater the conflict and the more impossible the obstacle, the more legendary the hero's journey is to its audience.

Conflict is the element that holds the audience's attention throughout the play. The audience came to see someone deal with a problem. The conflict should build continuously throughout the play and create urgency with the characters involved. As an audience member you get to escape your reality and problems and witness another person's struggle in order to gain perspective on your current or future situations. It is for this reason that you must make sure that your conflict builds in intensity and reaches a satisfying conclusion.

As soon as the conflict is resolved your audience will begin disengaging from your story and reentering their own lives. This is often a problem for new writers who create a conflict and then quickly resolve it thus terminating the audience's attention. It is possible to layer obstacles so that the audience stays engaged but you need to have a primary conflict for your story. Next you can have a series of smaller conflicts or obstacles that build tension as the story progresses, however you **MUST** introduce the next obstacle prior to the conclusion of the current obstacle. For example, if your main character needs to get to Las Vegas. Once they get to Las Vegas the audience feels that they have now completed the journey and will be furious if you introduce the new obstacle of getting to Denver once the characters have landed. Instead it is much more effective to have the characters discover while in flight that the venue they are traveling to or person they are pursuing has transferred to Denver, and they must adjust their plans. You have to stay ahead of your audience, if your audience knows what your characters are going to do, before they do it, your audience will be bored and you will lose them.

Conflict can take many forms, but is primarily broken into two main categories and each has several subcategories. The categories are as follows:

### **Internal (Human vs. Self)**

Mental

Emotional/Spiritual

Physical

### **External (Human vs. Something Outside of Themselves)**

Human Vs. Human

Human Vs. Nature

Human Vs. Supernatural

Human Vs. Society

Human Vs. Science

### Internal Conflict

Internal conflict represents the battles human beings have with themselves. Every story will contain internal conflict as it gives your character depth and instills a deeper humanity within the character. Also, every story should have internal conflict because the audience needs to see themselves as the main character and human beings are flawed. Human beings make mistakes and have character flaws and doubts along their journeys through life. Any achievement of substance by a human was met with adversity and doubt and you want your play to represent that basic human struggle.

Human beings are constantly searching to improve themselves and improve their circumstances but often our biggest obstacle is ourselves. In storytelling internal conflict usually manifests itself in mental, emotional/ spiritual, and physical forms.

### Human vs self (mental)

Mental conflict is where we battle our own mind. This type of conflict is usually manifested in a mental illness or disability, but it can take other forms. Stories in this category are very powerful struggles between our protagonist and their own mind, which are amplified examples of struggles we face every day. Typically, our main character struggles with mental challenges and through preserving against the challenges, accepting circumstances, and finally embracing their gifts they are able to succeed.

### Human vs self (emotional/spiritual)

Emotional or spiritual conflict is where our main character has a crisis of faith or is emotionally torn between two impossible choices. We have all been in a situation where we had to make a choice in a lose lose situation and decide between the lesser of two evils. This conflict can also manifest itself in love stories. A lover choosing between being happy with the person they love, or placing the needs of the person they love before their own. Strong emotional conflict is why Casablanca is still one of the most treasured films in cinematic history.

One of the most powerful examples of spiritual conflict I can think of was with a friend of mine who spent his entire childhood and young adult life preparing to become a priest. Yet before he went to take his vows the scandal of the Catholic Church hiding sexual predators within the clergy was released. My friend could not believe that God would allow this type of behavior in his establishment and because the abuse had gone on for so long and with no repercussions his crisis of faith was so intense he stopped believing in God. These types of emotional conflict happens on a small scale in our lives everyday, and at least once in our lives we have to face a major spiritual/emotional conflict and these stories are guides to help us navigate this trauma when it comes.

### Human vs self (Physical)

Internal physical conflict can be where a character is fighting a terminal illness, physical disability, or addiction. Many times this story shows us a character who in many ways 'has everything' and then loses part of their identity once the physical conflict is introduced. These stories are inspiring and heartbreaking and celebrate human perseverance. Often the struggle with physical conflict is centered around sacrifice, acceptance, and redefining your identity through the trials the conflict forced you to face.

## External Conflict

External conflict is where the obstacles and trials the protagonist is forced to encounter are coming from external or exterior sources. Most of the stories we read and see fall into these categories, but remember that each story should retain elements of internal conflict in order for the protagonist to grow and develop into the hero. External conflict has 5 sub categories: Human vs. Human, Human vs. Nature, Human vs. Supernatural, Human vs. Society, and Human vs. Science.

### Human vs. Human

Human vs. Human conflict is where you have a protagonist and an antagonist of equal abilities who square off against each other in the conflict of the story. This could be a romance in which a lover has a rival, it could be a crime drama where the anti-hero has a nemesis, but it can also be an animal vs. another animal, or wizard vs. wizard, or even someone with a super power vs. another supernatural entity. What matters in this conflict is that both the protagonist and the antagonist are equally matched. This does not mean that they are equally matched at the beginning of the story. There is a stronger payoff if the protagonist must grow and develop through the trials and conflict to unlock hidden potential to become the antagonists equal.

In this type of conflict remember that the protagonist or hero is only as strong as the antagonist or villain they are pitted against. The key to this conflict is establishing and developing a strong antagonist. Create a rival who has a flaw and let the protagonist share this flaw and overcome it.

### Human vs. Nature

Human vs. Nature is the conflict between humans and elements of nature. This antagonist can be an animal, human nature, or an environment. Usually a character is placed in an unfamiliar and dangerous setting which creates the need for survival. These stories focus on a human being's ability to be resourceful, deal with trauma, and endure trauma.

On a side note, since zombie stories are very popular I feel the need to point out that if the zombie virus is a natural pathogen it can fit in this category. There are some stories where the zombie pathogen is rabies or some other variant and in these situations it causes human beings to revert to their most primal urges and the conflict is really stemming from human nature.

## Human vs. SuperNatural

Human vs. Supernatural conflict is where the antagonist is something powerful and outside of nature. Many entities fall into this category such as ghosts, monsters, angels and demons, gods, time, and fate. In each story the supernatural entity is usually a metaphor for a problem most humans face. For example, ghost stories are all about secrets. Information is hidden and torments all those around it. It is only when the truth is exposed that the ghost can be confronted and defeated.

Monsters are metaphors for choices or systems we allow to consume or destroy our lives, angels/demons and gods represent our struggle to battle corruption within ourselves and society, and time and fate is a metaphor for the battle to create a legacy or impact within our short time on this earth. Each of these elements are big philosophical ideas that humans have struggled with since the beginning of time, condensing them into a story and masking them in metaphor allows your audience to digest the information and work out an answer for themselves.

## Human vs. Society

Human vs. Society is a conflict between the protagonist and a group. This group can be an institution, a small group within the setting, or a full scale society. In this conflict however there will usually be a figurehead who will become the mouthpiece for the collective group.

Societal conflict is often a battle for justice. The protagonist usually begins the story as part of the group they will later fight. The conflict emerges when an event causes the protagonist to be introduced into the world of the oppressed group and in that world the protagonist sees the beauty of the group and finds that their true place is within that society. The protagonist must then come into conflict with the larger group they were once a part of and with the knowledge and experience gained from both groups they are able to achieve justice and a new order is established.

## Human vs. Science

Human vs. Science is the battle between humans and the things we create. This type of conflict often allows you to explore hypothetical ideas, worries, and philosophies in order to create a dialogue with your audience. Think of this conflict as a modern rendition of Pandora's Box. Something is created and its power unleashed within the world.

### Playwriting Activity 1: Finding Conflict in Film

- Choose 2 films and identify the conflict. How does the conflict drive the actions of the characters? How does the conflict build? How does the conflict support the theme?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a conflict you can agree on.

### Playwriting Activity 2: Finding Conflict in Plays

- Choose 2 plays and identify the conflict. How does the conflict drive the actions of the characters? How does the conflict build? How does the conflict support the theme?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a conflict you can agree on.

### Playwriting Activity 3: Developing Conflict Through Your Ideas

- Go to the list of themes you created in the chapter on Theme, choose 2 themes and pair them with a type of conflict. Select a conflict that can be the driving force of your story and identify how it will support your theme. Simplify conflict into one sentence.
- Mix and match and see how the theme and conflict pairing transforms the way in which you deliver your story.
- Pick your 2 favorite pairings. Once selected, find a friend or partner and share your ideas.
- See how your partner responds to the themes. Discuss.

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## 1.7: Types of Story

I had been involved in theater for almost 20 years before I discovered Blake Snyder's book Save the Cat. Save the Cat has now become one of the standards in writing in Hollywood and is even referenced by George Lucas in his book on screenwriting. Blake Snyder's book was about screenwriting, yet had so many parallels to the storytelling of theater. One element of the book that broadened my perspective of storytelling was his section on the 10 different types of stories. Once his observation was pointed out I started to see how each type of conflict could fit neatly in each story type and I feel that this knowledge is incredibly helpful to anyone entering the art of storytelling. The following is my understanding of Blake Snyder's information but I encourage you to read the book for a deeper analysis.

Blake Snyder's The 10 types of Stories are as follows:

1. Monster in the House
2. Golden Fleece
3. Out of the Bottle
4. Buddy Love
5. Whydunit
6. Dude with a Problem
7. Institutionalized
8. Fool Triumphant
9. Rights of Passage
10. Super Hero

### Monster in the House

Monster in the house stories take us to our most primal instincts: Do not get eaten. The story usually centers around a protagonist who is trapped with a monster in a defined setting. The setting or 'house' can be a town, house, room, really anything as long as it is inescapable. The monster is typically a metaphor for the consequences brought upon by sin. An act of sin invites the monster into the setting and it is only after the sin is acknowledged and atoned for that the monster can be destroyed.

#### Ingredients

1. Monster
2. House
3. Sin

### Golden Fleece

Golden Fleece is a journey or quest story. Golden Fleece stories usually have a prize or goal that the main character needs to obtain or achieve. This goal or prize is time sensitive and the protagonist often assembles a team along the way to achieve this goal or obtain the prize. The joy of the Golden Fleece story is in the journey not in reaching the destination.

#### Ingredients

1. Team
2. Journey
3. Prize

### Out of the Bottle

Out of the bottle stories are parables about people appreciating what they have and making the necessary changes to maintain the things you treasure. In an Out of the Bottle story you have a character who is either really successful or struggling with their situation. A wish is expressed and a spell or plot device is introduced that takes the protagonist and places them in circumstances that are the antithesis of their current existence. The audience enjoys witnessing the protagonist navigate the new world and eventually the protagonist realizes that the skills developed in their previous situation are what make them special. The lesson is then learned and the protagonist returns to their previous existence armed with new knowledge and confidence for the road ahead.

#### Ingredients

1. Wish

2. Spell
3. Lesson

## Buddy Love

Buddy love stories are stories about relationships. These are stories about human beings finding love and purpose in the beings we interact with. Some stories can be about friendship, others romantic love, and some about pets or even robots. In a buddy love story you have a protagonist who is incomplete yet does not realize something is missing in their life. A counterpart is introduced who is the antithesis of the protagonist and carries the missing component that will make the protagonist complete. The story progresses and the protagonist and counterpart clash in style, approach, and perspective yet slowly discover each others strengths. A complication is introduced that tears the team apart and through this complication the team is reformed and each borrows lessons learned from the other.

### Ingredients

1. Incomplete Hero
2. Counterpart
3. Complication

## Whydunit

A Whydunit is a detective story or a mystery. A character begins solving a problem that gets more dangerous the more they learn and the closer they come to uncovering the secret or whatever is hidden. The protagonist does not need to be a detective, but they will still perform the role of a detective in that they will collect and decipher clues and use their knowledge to solve the mystery. The dark turn is the point in the story where the hunt for truth becomes dangerous for the protagonist and the protagonist is no longer safe whether or not the truth is revealed. It is called a whydunit because the most interesting element of the story is motive rather than the identity of the perpetrator. The audience does not care about who did the crime as much as why they did it.

### Ingredients

1. Detective
2. Secret
3. Dark Turn

## Dude With a Problem

Dude or rather Human with a problem stories are when a protagonist is forced to confront a conflict by happenstance. The protagonist was attending their daily activities and are forced to respond to a sudden event that has now caused a life or death situation.

### Ingredients

1. Innocent Hero
2. Sudden Event
3. Test of Survival

## Institutionalized

Institutionalized stories are centered around an individual's battle with a society, group, or institution. There is often a group that the protagonist belongs to and through an event or series of events the character is forced into a world that has them make a choice to confront either an opposite society/institution/group or their own society/institution/group. Finally, a sacrifice must be made in order to secure the new order established after the conflict. Sometimes the sacrifice is a member of the group, sometimes it is a sacred object or ideal, and sometimes it is the protagonist themselves.

### Ingredients

1. Group
2. Choice
3. Sacrifice

## Fool Triumphant

The fool triumphant story is about a protagonist who is unaware of any greatness they may possess. The fool enters a world, establishment, or institution and due to the fool's lack of awareness causes conflict. The world, establishment, or institution tries with all its might to destroy the fool, but the fool narrowly escapes each attempt through luck and happenstance. Eventually, the fool becomes aware of the establishment and through the trials of the story is able to mutate into a hero and bring down the establishment to create positive change.

### Ingredients

1. Fool
2. Establishment
3. Transmutation

## Rights of Passage

A rights of passage story is usually centered around internal conflict. The protagonist is confronted with a life problem that upends their normal existence and sends them on a path of self discovery. The protagonist spends much of the story dealing with and confronting the problem in counter productive and damaging ways that leave them weaker than when the conflict was introduced. Finally, the protagonist is able to accept their situation and only through acceptance can a new life or existence begin.

1. Life Problem
2. Wrong Way
3. Acceptance

## Super Hero

The Super Hero story is not always about individuals with magical abilities, but rather focuses on the burden of possessing talents. The protagonist is endowed with a special power of some sort, this could be public speaking, leadership, or some kind of unique gift or talent. This talent is both a blessing and a curse because it is a barrier between the hero and the society in which the hero resides. A Nemesis is introduced who is ruthless in the pursuit of their own goal and knows that the hero is a threat. The nemesis will often offer a position of power or status within the society. The hero must make a choice to accept the power as a blessing and willingly accept the burden of the curse, to defeat the Nemesis.

### Ingredients

1. Special Power
2. Nemesis
3. Curse

#### Playwriting Activity 1: Identifying types of story in popular films

- Pick 2 films and identify the type of stories they are. Can you identify the essential ingredients? Is there another story type the film could fit into? If so which is the better fit?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a story type you can agree on.

#### Playwriting Activity 2: Identifying types of story in popular plays

- Pick 2 plays and identify the type of story they are. Can you identify the essential ingredients? Is there another story type the play could fit into? If so which is the better fit?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a story type you can agree on.

#### Playwriting Activity 3: Selecting a Type of Story for Your Play

- Choose a theme you wrote down earlier in the Theme chapter. Pair the theme with a type of conflict.
- Pair your choices with each of the different story types and see how your story would change based on the pairing
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings.

- See how your partner responds and ask which story interests you and your partner the most.

Snyder, B. (2005). *Save the cat!: The last book on screenwriting you'll ever need*. Studio City, CA: M. Wiese Productions.

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## 1.8: Setting

The setting is the environment in which the conflict can take place. The conflict and setting will also contribute to the action (or things that happen) on stage. You can set your play in any location you choose and as many locations as you would like. You can have a single location or multiple locations however, there are pros and cons to each.

When creating a play imagine that the life of the character is continuous and the play takes place on the most important day or set of days in this character's life. Now you cannot stage the continuous life of this character uninterrupted because it would take too long, so you are choosing to show us the most important parts, of the most important day. Because you are selecting the most important events that happened on this day, all essential conflicts and actions should happen on stage. You want to make sure that the audience gets to be present for the major events, this will engage them more and allow them to feel as though they are part of the play.

### Single Location

If you choose to set your play in a single location your play will be easier to produce and will be more accessible to theater companies later. Having your play in one location also allows your set to be detailed and specific. Your designer is only working on one location so the designer can focus on specifics. The catch is that you have to choose a location where multiple characters would logically meet and engage in the story and conflict. If for instance you have set your play at a school, you may want to choose a location at the school that everyone would use like a courtyard or cafeteria rather than a classroom because you will create an opportunity to introduce more characters. Setting your play in one location can be difficult, but if it is possible, try to achieve it.

### Multiple Locations

If you choose to set your play in multiple locations then you are only limited by your imagination. You are free to take your audience to any location you choose at any moment, free from limitations. The drawback to this is that the more locations you choose to add into your play, the more money it will cost to produce it which can limit your accessibility, and the set design for each location will be less detailed than if you set it at one location. I have done plays with over 50 locations and some locations had to be suggested through lighting and sound only. Do not limit your creativity. Write your play the way you want, it is your play.

#### Playwriting Activity 1: Selecting a Single Location for your Play

- Choose a theme you wrote down earlier in the Theme chapter. Pair the theme with a type of conflict. Choose 3 settings in which this conflict can take place. Compare and contrast the choices. What characters would interact here? What possibilities does the location give you, are there drawbacks. Once you have compared the attributes of each set, select one.
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a location that might serve the play better.

#### Playwriting Activity 2: Creating Multiple Locations for your Play

- Choose a theme you wrote down earlier in the Theme chapter. Pair the theme with a type of conflict. Choose 2 settings in which this conflict can take place. Ask yourself "What possible locations are located within this setting?" Can you tell your story fully in these locations? Compare and contrast the choices. What characters would interact here? What possibilities does the location give you, are there drawbacks. Select your favorites.
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a theme you can agree on.

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## 1.9: Character and Story Archetypes

One of the most insightful and captivating histories on storytelling is Joseph Campbell's The Hero with a Thousand Faces. In the book he outlines how all myths and stories are analogies of the human experience and how each character and story archetype have counterparts to your life. The enduring quality of a myth is in its ability to teach and inspire the listener. There are many character and story archetypes yet each story has 5 essential archetypes. In some cases one character can be the vessel for several of the following types, yet these archetypes are always present in stories. The following are an amalgamation of many theories, yet the more you study story structure you will notice how each theory and perspective has many commonalities with its counterparts. The following is my attempt to combine them.

### The Hero

The hero is your lead character and the character that the audience is meant to identify with and the character is a representation of the audience member. The hero can be any gender, race, species, etc. but each hero must possess several qualities in order to be effective.

#### Hero Trait 1: A hero must have a good heart

A hero or antihero must deep down have a good heart. Even and especially when the character has a jaded past and has been damaged by the world, it is vital that the audience understand and see the hero as good. The audience must see themselves as the character in order to be invested in the story and each person always feels they are good or tries to have good intentions. This is why villains in history have been so scary, because each believed that they were doing just and good things by committing atrocities. Your character does not need to be overly good and can be a bad person most of the time, but you need to have at least one small moment where their inner goodness can be displayed.

#### Hero Trait 2: A Hero must know they are special, but not know why.

At the beginning of the journey the hero must know deep down that they are special and were meant to achieve a greater purpose. The problem that the character faces is that they do not know what that purpose is. In their current situation they do not see how they will ever be able to escape and discover who they are, let alone achieve something. The journey of your story is what will make the character's purpose clear, but at the beginning the audience needs to see the character's drive.

In class I always ask my students to raise their hand if they think they are special. Most of the time only a few do. I then ask, "Why did you not raise your hand? Is it because you truly do not believe you are special?" The truth is all people believe they are special and have big dreams, before life kicks them in the teeth. However, you would not have showed up to school, or work, or be reading this book if you did believe you had something to give to the world. Often we try to hide what our special qualities are and avoid voicing our dreams in order to avoid ridicule, but those desires are there in all humans. Each of us feels we have something to give and this has been the case since humans began telling stories. When we need inspiration we look to the stories we were told growing up, when we are broken we look to those heroes who overcame obstacles far scarier than our own. If your audience needs to see themselves in your hero then you need to make sure that this consistent human experience is part of your character's traits.

#### Hero Trait 3: The Hero must be the Chosen One

Only the hero can defeat the villain. The hero is the chosen one and with that power and responsibility the hero must fight their own battles. Can you imagine a story where you invested your time and love following a hero you thought to be the chosen one and in the end it was someone else and they were irrelevant? You would be furious! I am sure that the writers who did this in the past patted themselves on the back and felt superior to their audience, but that victory was short lived when that story was quickly forgotten. If you spent 8 Harry Potter books to find out that Neville Longbottom was the actual hero you would never pick up the books again. You invested and identified with the hero, it is your job to tell us how the hero defeats the villain. Now the hero does not need to win, but the hero had better go down trying because that is the human spirit and that will inspire us to keep going on our hero's journey.

In life you will have your villains that you will need to overcome. These villains will be your villains and your villains alone. If you are going to be an adult and achieve your greatness you will need to overcome your villains. Sometimes the villain is yourself, sometimes it is a struggle only you have, and heroes fight their battles and victims ask others to fight their battles for them. You are the hero in your life and this characteristic is central to the themes and lessons all stories have shared since humans began telling stories.

#### Hero Trait 4: A Hero needs a flaw

The flaw is an internal obstacle that must be overcome in order to defeat the villain. Often the hero and the villain share this flaw and are examples of how the flaw can shape your destiny and actions. In a true hero's journey the hero has to grow and mature as the story progresses. The character is following the same structure our lives follow, but in a condensed timeline. Every human being has flaws and internal battles needed to be overcome in order to progress towards our goals, this needs to be present with the main character in the story.

#### Hero Trait 5: A Hero needs to have a straightforward and urgent goal

Aaron Sorkin and William Goldman refer to this as the intention, others refer to it as a goal or need, others refer to it as the super objective. What matters is that the Hero has a goal/desire/intention that helps drive them through the plot and motivates them to keep going. Each scene and the play as a whole are an attempt to achieve this goal for the character. This is connected to characteristic 2 and this goal/need/intention will serve as the character's boon (or Prize) at the end of the journey or will be the character's downfall.

### The Villain

The Villain is the antagonist of the story and will come in any form needed and derived from the conflict. In an internal conflict the Villain and the Hero are one and the same. In external conflict the Villain can be nature, another human, a society, supernatural entity, or scientific construction. What matters is the Villain is the primary obstacle in the way of the Hero achieving their goal. The Villain also has characteristics shared throughout all stories.

#### Villain Trait 1: The Villain hates the Hero

The Villain often hates the hero for no other reason than that they are good. The Villain sees the Hero as a threat and because of this, tries to destroy the Hero only to find that in doing so it has prepared the Hero with the skills to overcome the Villain in the final confrontation.

#### Villain Trait 2: The Villain wants to possess or destroy the Heroine/Goal/McGuffin

The Villain is the antagonist of the story because it seeks to possess or destroy something of great importance to the world of the Hero. The Villain is singular in its pursuit of the Heroine/Goal/McGuffin and possess such a threat to the world of the story that the audience is compelled to root for the hero.

#### Villain Trait 3: The less we know about the Villain the better

The audience does not need nor do they care about the Villain's backstory. They are content with the knowledge that the Villain is evil. The more backstory you give to your Villain the more sympathetic you make them and you risk the audience identifying more with your Villain than your Hero. You want the villain to seem scary, powerful, and invincible so that the audience learns the lessons of self development and courage the journey is reinforcing. Neil Gaiman said "Stories are important not because they teach us that dragons are real, but that dragons can be defeated." Remember that the villain represents intense struggles we, as the audience, will encounter in our lives and it is important to have us identify with the Hero more than the trail we will later face.

#### Villain Trait 4: The Villain has to destroy something precious or do something truly terrible to solidify the audience's hatred.

Even though the audience will be content with the knowledge that the Villain is evil, you will need to have the Villain do something truly terrible to reinforce the audience's hatred of the villain. The action the Villain takes will also serve as a defining moment for the Hero where failure to defeat the Villain no longer becomes an option and the final confrontation must happen. The more the audience hates the Villain the more they will root for the Hero.

One of the best speeches concerning stories that I can remember comes from the film Lord of the Rings: The Two Towers. Towards the end of the film the hero and his sidekick are exhausted and running from both humans and monsters that have tried to kill them. The Hero looks around in the middle of a battle and sees the carnage all being caused because of his journey. He sits down in the middle of the battlefield and decides to give up. His sidekick sits down next to him and says "It's like in the old stories, the ones that really mattered. The heroes were fighting against villains that were so powerful you thought that there was no way they could win. But they kept going and in the end they did win. Those are the stories that stuck with us. Those are the stories worth telling."

## The Heroine/ Goal/ McGuffin/ Stakes

This archetype goes by many names, but is crucial for the plot. The Heroine/ Goal/ McGuffin/ Stakes is the noun (person, place, or thing) that the characters are fighting to protect. What are all of the characters fighting to save or protect? This could be a house, legacy, the world, a person, a document, etc. Each character cares about this noun and it is the driving force behind the conflict. You must be able to clearly identify it or you will need to raise the stakes of your story. If the characters do not know what they are fighting for neither will your audience and you will lose them. Ask yourself what is the conflict over? What are the characters fighting to save?

This ties to your real life in that each of us has unique things we treasure and strive to protect. The conflicts in your life that will shape you will have this treasured item at stake and these stories help to prepare us both in strategy and experience for the trials to come.

## The Sidekick

The sidekick is the friend or helper on the hero's journey. The sidekick helps the Hero overcome the Villain and saves the Hero at least once on the journey. The Sidekick is brave, loyal, and has all of the characteristics of the hero except one. The Sidekick is not the chosen one. However, the Hero can only defeat the Villain with the help of the Sidekick, but the Sidekick would lose if ever to encounter the Villain alone.

The Sidekick is a representation of the friends we encounter on our life's journey. As a Hero you are going to face Villians that only you can defeat and save things that you care about. In your journey you can defeat any Villain you encounter, and achieve any goal you set, but all stories teach us that you can never accomplish anything alone. You will need friends. You will need friends who help shape you into the Hero you will become and also pick you up when the world has crushed you. However, your Villians are your Villains and your Villains alone. Your friends cannot fight your battles for you, merley support you in your endeavor, for they have their own Villains in their personal stories they must defeat.

## The Mentor

The Mentor is the Teacher in the story. The Mentor helps the Hero unlock their true potential. The Mentor does not fully train or prepare the Hero for the Villain, because the journey does that. The Mentor's purpose is to help the Hero discover their potential so that it can be developed. Once the Hero's potential has been unlocked, the Mentor will encounter a barrier that it cannot cross. In some stories the teacher cannot leave the school, a trainer cannot enter the ring, in religion God cannot come down from the heavens, and in some stories the mentor dies. The barrier is important because if the Hero has a Mentor that is more powerful than themselves, then there is no reason to step up and become the Hero. The Mentor is removed from the story so that the Hero has no one to hide behind and no choice but to step up to the Hero's challenges.

The Mentor of the story represents the influential adults in our lives that help prepare us for the obstacles ahead. In life, your teachers do not follow you outside of school, your parents will kick you out of the nest or will eventually die, and you must step up and become the guiding force in your own life. You will take the lessons you garnered from them and use them as you navigate your path, but each story attempts to prepare you for this step along the way.

### Playwriting Activity 1: Identifying Archetypes in Stories

- Choose a film, play, book, and TV Commercial and identify the archetypes of each story. Which characters and entities served each archetype? Did any characters fulfill multiple archetypes?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a new perspective that you both agree on.

### PLAYWRITING Activity 2: Creating Archetypes for your story

- Choose a theme, conflict, and setting from the previous activities and create a Hero, Villain, Sidekick, Heroine/Goal/McGuffin, and Mentor that will help you tell your story.
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a theme you can agree on.



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## 1.10: Plot

Every play is different and every new playwright is not only developing their voice, but also trying to break the rules. However, human beings have been telling stories since before we ever developed written language. Stories are how histories were passed down, how life lessons were learned, and how we found our place in society. There is a wonderful book called The Storytelling Animal by Jonathan Gottschall and in the book he talks about how human beings have evolved around story. We wake up and eat breakfast and read stories either on the phone, on the cereal box, or watch them on the television. We then go to school or work and listen to information that if it is told in story form we remember more easily. On breaks we see our friends and tell them about the stories of our day. We then go home and watch stories on the television, our phone, or read stories. Finally, we go to sleep and dream in stories. Every part of our existence is tied to stories. Religion is just a story large groups of people feel is so important it has become sacred. Because stories are the vehicle of communication with our species and as a theater artist you are a storyteller, it is a good idea to understand how a story is constructed.

Plot is just another name for Story. Plot is the series of events that are structured to take the hero on a transformative journey throughout the story. Stories have been around for centuries and throughout that time the structure of storytelling has become solidified and with that there are essential components or rules you must follow. There are always attempts to break the form and some are done quite well, but if you just follow the structure and deliver a strong and well crafted story your audience will be receptive and happy. Each plot or story has essential components and below I will briefly outline them. I will first outline the minimum essential plot points you will need in any story, joke, etc. and then I will provide a more detailed plot outline for you to follow if you choose.

### Minimum Essential components of a story:

- Set up / Prologue / Exposition
- Catalyst or Inciting Incident
- Rising Action
- Finale/Climax
- Denouement or Resolution

### Setup/Prologue/Exposition

The setup/prologue/exposition is set up within the first 10-12 pages of the play. Every story whether it be a novel, play, story you tell your friend, or even a joke has to have certain elements in the beginning in order for your audience to understand and follow the plot. If the following elements are not clear in the beginning of the story the audience will spend most of the play/story trying to figure them out and as a result will not be following your actual story. In the set up you have to establish the setting/ time/ location, introduce the main characters, set up the rules of the world, and establish what a normal day is like in the main characters world.

#### Establish the Setting:

The audience needs to understand where and when the play is taking place. Remember that in a play the action and story is being conveyed through dialogue and will need to be clearly established up front. You even do this when telling a quick story to your friend: “Last I was walking into Wal-Mart and \_\_\_\_\_”

or in a joke: “2 guys walk into a bar.”

or in a Fairy Tale: “Once upon a time in a land far far away...”

In each instance the Setting is established up front so the audience has a location in which to stage the rest of the story.

#### Introducing the Main Characters:

Within the first few pages of the story the audience needs to be introduced to the main characters they will be following for the journey of the play. The audience needs to know who to care about and identify with. If you want the audience to bond with your character, it helps to have the protagonist do a small act of kindness to allow us to see the characters potential as a hero. The audience does not need backstory, but they do need to be aware of the principal players in the world of the story.

#### Setting Up the Rules of the World:

Every story takes place in an alternate reality and each reality has a set of rules that the characters must abide by. If your characters are in a world where ghosts or magic exists, you must establish this early so that when these elements are explored later the

audience is with you. You have to clearly establish these rules early so that they can be used later in the story.

Even in situations where the story seems realistic there are rules. For example, every romance has the rule or convention that “love at first sight” exists as well as the rule/convention/concept of the existence of a “true love.” In a story the author needs the audience to root for the leads to get together and since the author is limited to a two hour narrative the easiest way to establish a strong connection is to create the existence of “Love at First Sight.” This rule is not realistic because the only human beings that truly believe in love at first sight are stalkers, but the convention or rule allows the author to establish a connection between the main characters and then use the rest of the time to focus on the plot elements that help tell the actual story.

The concept of “True Love” is also useful and equally counter to real life. The rule of true loves existence allows for the audience to understand that the main characters share a special bond and connection that is worth enduring the trials of the story. In real life human beings have complicated relationships with everything. Do you love your parents? Do you love your spouse or significant other? Do you love your children? Do you love food? Now do you love all of those things the same way? NO!! That is both disgusting and illegal, but you cannot say that your love for any of those things is less ‘true’ than the other. Nevertheless the concept of a true love allows the author to establish a worthy connection between the characters and convinces the audience to root for the characters to get together.

### **Establishing Normal:**

For the purpose of telling your story you need to establish what the rules of the imaginary world you are creating are and then show us what a normal and average day in this world, with these rules, looks like. It is very important to do this because when you introduce the conflict it will disrupt the normal flow of the world and both the characters and the audience will see it.

### **Catalyst/Inciting Incident**

The inciting incident or catalyst is the thing that happens that causes everything else to happen. This is the event that will introduce the conflict of the story. This can be a character being introduced, an event occurring, or something as small as a letter being dropped off. This is the plot device that disrupts the normal life you have established and sets the plot in motion. Ultimately, this is where the problem is introduced that you are going to spend the rest of the story solving. While there are many points in the rising action and prologue/exposition, there is only one inciting incident.

### **Rising Action**

The rising action is the series of events that build tension and lead towards the finale and climax. The rising action is the struggle and the sole reason the audience is watching the show. Once the problem has been introduced through the Inciting Incident, the character then tries to solve this problem and in doing so creates more struggles and obstacles. Each scene is an attempt to solve the problem and each attempt is unsuccessful and increases the hero’s struggle. Each scene should build in intensity and be harder for the hero to overcome, but along the way you want the hero to gain knowledge and skills that will help solve the problem in the end. Remember: Each obstacle increases the suffering of the protagonist and each obstacle helps prepare the protagonist for the final confrontation with the antagonist. Do not be afraid to make things hard for your hero. The more the character suffers, the more the audience suffers and that suffering is matched in the relief and celebration shared by the hero achieving the end goal.

### **Finale**

The finale is the strongest point of conflict where the hero and antagonist collide. The more the hero has struggled throughout the journey, the more the audience has anticipated this confrontation, so make sure to capitalize on this by increasing the heroes struggles leading up to this point.

### **Climax**

The climax is the highest point of tension. Tension is created when we are anticipating an event but it has yet to occur. This is the moment where you extend the anticipation of victory or defeat, because once the event occurs it becomes part of the resolution and the audience will begin the process of disengaging from the performance and reconnecting with their lives. This is why kisses take so long in dramas. The audience understands the finality of the kiss, within the rules of the world. A kiss seals the relationship of the couple, and so the more you make the audience wait, the more they root for your characters.

### **Denouement / Falling Action / Resolution**

Denouement means to unravel or unknot. The plot has been building tension and tying knots in the audiences stomachs and denouement is where the story receives closure and the knots are untied. In the Denouement the conflict is resolved, the hero is either victorious or fails, life returns to as normal as possible for the characters following the events of the plot, and the audience

begins to internalize the themes and knowledge gained from the story. This should not take too long, and do get 'precious' or sentimental with the subject matter. This is the final 5 pages or less of the script.

## More Detailed Plot Description

Some stories need the loose structure of Minimum Components outline, however most stories follow the following plot outline. This list combines many different theories and techniques of plot structure and consolidates them. Remember that all stories are metaphors for the audience to learn from and your goal should be to connect your hero with your audience and through the journey transform your audience through your character.

### Standard components of a story:

- Opening Image
- Set up / Prologue / Exposition
- Catalyst or Inciting Incident
- Debate
- Decision
- Fun and Games or New World
- Midpoint
- Bad Guys Close In or Tensions Rise
- All is Lost
- Dark night of the Soul
- Finale
- Denouement or Resolution
- Final Image

### Another way of looking at plot:

Setup/Exposition

- Opening Image
- Set up / Prologue / Exposition

Catalyst or Inciting Incident

Rising Action

- Debate
- Decision
- Fun and Games or New World
- Midpoint
- Bad Guys Close In or Tensions Rise
- All is Lost
- Dark night of the Soul

Finale

Climax

Denouement or Resolution

## Opening Image

Every single story is about a transformation. Blake Snyder describes this beautifully in his book Save the Cat. He says "Every play is about the transformation of a caterpillar into a butterfly." Every story is also a hero's journey. We are introduced to a hero who, like us, is trapped in circumstances they cannot control. Yet this hero has a goal and in order to achieve that goal they will be met with many obstacles. It is watching this character overcome the obstacles that transforms not only the hero but the audience. The opening image is where the story shows us the main character in the beginning or caterpillar stage of their journey. This is important because the opening image and final image are the things your audience will remember the most. It is the contrast of these two images that tell the story.

## Setup/Prologue/Exposition

Every story has to have certain elements in the beginning in order for your audience to understand and follow the plot. In the set up you have to establish the setting or time and location, introduce the main characters, set up the rules of the world, and establish what a normal day is like in the main characters world.

### Establish the Setting:

The audience needs to understand where and when the play is taking place. Remember that in a play the action and story is being conveyed through dialogue and will need to be clearly established up front. You even do this when telling a quick story to your friend: “Last I was walking into Wal-Mart and \_\_\_\_\_”

or in a joke: “2 guys walk into a bar.”

or in a Fairy Tale: “Once upon a time in a land far far away...”

In each instance the Setting is established up front so the audience has a location in which to stage the rest of the story.

### Introducing the Main Characters:

Within the first few pages of the story the audience needs to be introduced to the main characters they will be following for the journey of the play. The audience needs to know who to care about and identify with. If you want the audience to bond with your character, it helps to have the protagonist do a small act of kindness to allow us to see the characters potential as a hero. The audience does not need backstory, but they do need to be aware of the principal players in the world of the story.

If this is a love story, the audience needs to see a selfish and childish hero who avoids responsibility and only strives to have fun. We then need to see the over responsible counterpart that is overstressed, overworked, and avoids fun and risk at all cost. These characters behavior, flaws, and routines need to be established so that when they meet in the inciting incident, the audience understands the journey each character needs to undertake.

### Setting Up the Rules of the World:

Every story takes place in an alternate reality and each reality has a set of rules that the characters must abide by. If your characters are in a world where ghosts or magic exists, you must establish this early so that when these elements are explored later the audience is with you. You have to clearly establish these rules early so that they can be used later in the story.

Even in situations where the story seems realistic there are rules. For example, every romance has the rule or convention that “love at first sight” exists as well as the rule/convention/concept of the existence of a “true love.” In a story the author needs the audience to root for the leads to get together and since the author is limited to a two hour narrative the easiest way to establish a strong connection is to create the existence of “Love at First Sight.” This rule is not realistic because the only human beings that truly believe in love at first sight are stalkers, but the convention or rule allows the author to establish a connection between the main characters and then use the rest of the time to focus on the plot elements that help tell the actual story.

The concept of “True Love” is also useful and equally counter to real life. The rule of true loves existence allows for the audience to understand that the main characters share a special bond and connection that is worth enduring the trials of the story. In real life human beings have complicated relationships with everything. Do you love your parents? Do you love your spouse or significant other? Do you love your children? Do you love food? Now do you love all of those things the same way? NO!! That is both disgusting and illegal, but you cannot say that your love for any of those things is less ‘true’ than the other. Nevertheless the concept of a true love allows the author to establish a worthy connection between the characters and convinces the audience to root for the characters to get together.

### Establishing Normal:

For the purpose of telling your story you need to establish what the rules of the imaginary world you are creating are and then show us what a normal and average day in this world, with these rules, looks like. It is very important to do this because when you introduce the conflict it will disrupt the normal flow of the world and both the characters and the audience will see it. It is also important to note that the world of the exposition is not maintainable and if life were to continue this way for the character the characters would either die or live wasted and meaningless lives. Even if their life is filled with happiness, it is unfulfilled in ways they are not yet aware of and that is why the story is worth telling.

## Catalyst/Inciting Incident

The inciting incident or catalyst is the thing that happens that causes everything else to happen. This is the event that will introduce the conflict of the story. This can be a character being introduced, an event occurring, or something as small as a letter being dropped off. This is the plot device that disrupts the normal life you have established and sets the plot in motion. Ultimately, this is where the problem is introduced that you are going to spend the rest of the story solving. While there are many points in the rising action and prologue/exposition, there is only one inciting incident.

### Debate

Once the Catalyst or Inciting Incident has occurred the Hero contemplates taking the journey to confront the problem. Most human beings never feel ready to take on a difficult task, let alone a life defining journey. This plot point is really important to have because it highlights a truly human characteristic. Every great hero does not go willingly at first to their destiny, they doubt themselves. This contemplation is usually a discussion with a friend or mentor, but can also be a soliloquy.

### Decision

The Hero does not always make the decision to go on a journey to confront the problem. This is the plot point where the decision is made. The Hero either decides to confront the problem willingly or the villain/circumstances make a decision that forces the hero into action.

### Fun and Games/ New World

The main character begins the journey to confront the problem and this forces the character to enter a new world. The new world is the antithesis of the previous world and all of the rules from the previous world are broken. The section is called 'fun and games' by some writers but this does not necessarily mean that the world the character is entering is fun. The fun comes from the exploration of the world. Your main character is clueless to the rules of this world, as is your audience, and both will discover the world together. If for example the world of the exposition is safe and predictable, the hero must enter a world that is dangerous and unpredictable. This section is rather long and allows for new characters to be introduced. This is also why your hero is clueless at the beginning of the story, because as you introduce the new world to them the audience is equally clueless and you can hide any further exposition in dialogue or actions by the hero asking questions or discovering things on their own.

### Midpoint

The midpoint of the play is where the main character has adequately explored the new world and has unlocked a piece of hidden potential. This event usually manifests itself into a 'false victory' or 'false defeat.' This means that the character has a minor confrontation with another character and through the confrontation learns a new skill. This confrontation can either be a victory or defeat, but it is labeled as 'false' because there is much more to learn and the final confrontation is yet to come. Immediately following the midpoint is the intermission.

### Bad Guys Close In/ Tensions Rise

Following the victory or defeat at the midpoint the Antagonist becomes aware of the hero and adds pressure. If the hero is part of a team, the team begins to struggle and fall apart. Relationships that were strong in Act 1 now begin to fracture. In addition the hero begins to doubt their abilities, the process, and begins losing faith in themselves and their team.

### All is lost

This is a major defeat at the hands of the antagonist causing the team to completely fracture and in the process destroys the heroes confidence. This can be the perceived loss of the goal, a character dying, something being lost, etc. In life each person is going to be hit with events that crush any semblance of what we thought we were. This plot point illustrates that in story form and has characters struggle with an equal loss. Due to this loss, all progress made feels lost and the final problem appears insurmountable.

### Dark Night of the Soul

This is the part of the story where the Hero contemplates giving up and in some cases even ending their life. As the Hero decides whether or not to continue, he or she is offered guidance by a sidekick or mentor and through this conversation the hero finally understands the deeper meaning of the theme. At the end of the scene, the hero decides to meet the antagonist in a final confrontation. The parallel in life is that only once we hit rock bottom can we begin anew and if you build on the lessons you have learned along your journey you can become the unstoppable force you were looking for all along.

### Finale

The finale is the strongest point of conflict where the hero and antagonist collide. The more the hero has struggled throughout the journey, the more the audience has anticipated this confrontation, so make sure to capitalize on this by increasing the hero's struggles leading up to this point. At this point the protagonist and antagonist are equally matched and now the hero is armed with experience and an unwavering understanding of the theme of the story. The protagonist and antagonist collide and the finale should be designed to test both characters to their breaking points.

### **Climax**

The climax is the highest point of tension. Tension is created when we are anticipating an event but it has yet to occur. This is the moment where you extend the anticipation of victory or defeat, because once the event occurs it becomes part of the resolution and the audience will begin the process of disengaging from the performance and reconnecting with their lives.

### **Denouement / Falling Action / Resolution**

Denouement means to unravel or unknot. The plot has been building tension and tying knots in the audience's stomachs and denouement is where the story receives closure and the knots are untied. In the Denouement the conflict is resolved, the hero is either victorious or fails, life returns to as normal as possible for the characters following the events of the plot, and the audience begins to internalize the themes and knowledge gained from the story. This should not take too long, and do get 'precious' or sentimental with the subject matter.

### **Closing Image**

This is our final moment or image of the character as the transformed butterfly. This image should be powerful and will be the image your audience will carry with them out of the theater.

#### Playwriting Activity 1: Identifying the Set up

- Choose a film, play, or book, and ask yourself “what does the audience need to know in order for the world to make sense.” Identify which characters tell the audience this and how the information is conveyed?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a new perspective that you both agree on.

#### Playwriting Activity 2: Identifying Plot Structure

- Choose a film, play, book, and TV Commercial and identify the plot points in the story. Were you able to find all of them? Were any missing? Did this support or hinder the story?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a new perspective that you both agree on.

#### Playwriting Activity 3: Creating a Plot Structure about a Public Figure

- Choose a public figure that you are familiar with and outline their political career. Identify a problem within that career that needed to be faced. Choose a theme, conflict, and setting. Create a Hero, Villain, Sidekick, Heroine/Goal/McGuffin, and Mentor that will help you tell your story. Then incorporate the events in the person's career into a plot structure that you have learned. Do the events build tension? How does the conflict get worse? What did the character learn at the end?
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a more effective progression for your story.

#### Playwriting Activity 4: Creating Tension in the Rising Action

- Choose a theme, conflict, and setting from the previous activities and create a Hero, Villain, Sidekick, Heroine/Goal/McGuffin, and Mentor that will help you tell your story. Then create an outline where in the setup you introduce your characters and the world. Then use the Inciting Incident to introduce your conflict/ problem. Then outline a series of events that escalate the problem and build to a worst case scenario happening, then introduce a ticking clock.
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a more effective progression for your story.

### Playwriting 5: Brain Dump

- Choose a story you have had floating around in your head. Write out all of the events that you want to happen in the story. Once you have finished use flash cards or small strips of paper and write each event down so that each event is represented on a single sheet of paper. Choose your inciting incident and your climax. Organize your events in a logical progression that connect your Inciting Incident and your Climax.
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a more effective progression for your story.

### Playwriting 6: Creating your plot structure

- Choose a theme, conflict, and setting from the previous activities and create a Hero, Villain, Sidekick, Heroine/Goal/McGuffin, and Mentor that will help you tell your story. Identify a clear Inciting Incident that will begin the action and a Climax to build towards. Then create an outline where in the setup you introduce your characters and the world. Then use the Inciting Incident to introduce your conflict/ problem. Then outline a series of events that escalate the problem and build to a worst case scenario happening, add in a ticking clock and build towards your climax.
- Find a friend or partner and discuss your findings. Do you both agree with your findings? If not discuss and see if you can discover a more effective progression for your story.

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## 1.11: Dialogue

Dialogue is the primary tool used for storytelling in theater. Film uses imagery, novels use descriptions, comics use pictures, theater uses dialogue. As a playwright the audience will not read, hear, or see your stage directions, but they will hear every word of your dialogue. Dialogue and action are how you drive the plot, develop characters relationships, and tell your story. Dialogue is also used to reveal characters inner emotions, their past experiences, or their vulnerability and frustrations. A character also cannot overcome an obstacle or fulfill his/her needs alone so they are reliant on others for help. If a character needs money to get to the hospital, that character must spend the scene either finding money in the apartment or using dialogue to convince each person to give them money. Conversations are always based out of need and it is a means to fulfill that need. If a character is bored a conversation fills the time, if a character is lonely a conversation has the potential to fulfill the need for companionship. Ultimately dialogue should flow naturally and build toward the desired outcome of the scene.

The hard part of dialogue is figuring out how people actually talk. Each person you meet has a distinctive rhythm, flow, and vocabulary used while talking and as you create a world you want the characters in the world to also feel distinct. In order to get good at writing dialogue you are going to have to study conversations and many different people. Interview people, go to coffee shops and listen, or sit with friends and listen to how they interact with each other. How do their thoughts shift? What words do they use, would they make an interesting character in a play? What other kinds of characters do you think share those traits? As you train as a playwright you will need to be constantly creating scenarios where characters are working towards a goal or involved in a conflict and use dialogue as your means of resolving the problem. This will be difficult at first, but like everything, it will get easier with time. Side note: When writing DO NOT edit while you write. Edit once you have finished the scene.

*All of the action should be done through dialogue and physical action rather than narration. Remember show us don't tell us.*

### Playwriting Activity 1

- Go outside of class and record a conversation and write it down. Go to various locations and listen to interactions between people. Study verbiage, delivery, and subject matter. See if you can decipher each person's need.
- Write a dialogue between two imaginary characters.
- Give both conversations (one real and one fictional) to a friend and see if they can determine which conversation is the real one.
- Repeat until you are good enough to fool your audience.

### Playwriting Activity 2

- Write a dialogue that introduces a conflict
- Write the following scene where the dialogue further develops the conflict and stakes raise for the main character.

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## 1.12: Creating Characters

Creating original characters is one of the most fun and rewarding experiences you will have as an artist. You are bringing something into being through your imagination and audience members will live and see the world through this character's eyes and experiences and often this fictional character will make a lasting impact on actual people's lives.

When creating characters you want to make sure that each individual in your play has a direct tie to the conflict and theme of your story. If for example your conflict or story centers around a plane crashing or disappearing, you want to start by creating the character by its relationship to the event: "I am the captain of the plane that crashed" "I am the widow of a passenger on the plane that crashed" "I am the flight controller that last spoke to the pilot of the plane that crashed" etc.

This allows you to start with a character directly tied to the event and therefore logically connected to your play. This character is not defined by gender, name, personality, etc. at this point. Once you have created enough characters from this exercise you can begin giving them an identity.

There are many ways you can explore and develop character's identities. You can ask actors to improvise a backstory and interview the character. You can go to a public place and base a character off of people you observe. You can base a character off of a friend or acquaintance. Or you can simply use your imagination and create the character from your head.

One primary component that a character must possess is a strong need or desire or goal that drives their actions and is tied directly to the conflict of the play. Character is all action and character is found and defined for the audience in the character's actions and how the character pursues their objective or goal. Make sure that each character in your play has a strong and identifiable need and allow that to guide the actions they take throughout the story.

Once you have selected the characters you wish to have in your play, then assign them to the archetypes in the previous chapter. Who will be your story's hero? Based on your choice of Hero, who will then be the story's villain? Who or what is the heroine/goal/ McGuffin? Who will be the mentor? Everyone else is a sidekick. Get rid of any character that does not directly serve the plot.

### Playwriting Activities

With each of the following activities you need to first and foremost have an idea or conflict upon which to base your play. Once you have the idea or conflict you then create a person based on their relationship to the idea or conflict. State the character existence as "I am the (Relationship) to/from the (Idea / Conflict)."

An example of this would be if your play were based on a conflict centered around an inheritance you would create a character with a phrase like: "I am the favorite child of the person who is bestowing the inheritance." or "I am the corrupt lawyer in charge of arbitrating the inheritance."

#### Actor Improvisation

- Create a list of characters and then invite actors to choose a character to inhabit or portray.
- Ask the actor to introduce the character to you and to begin by using elements of their real life and somewhere in the middle of the interview or introduction begin blending character information with the actors backstory. This allows you to have a backstory and origin of the character based on reality.
- Once the actor has introduced the character and talked for a few minutes. Interview them and ask questions. Write down phrases and facts that stand out.
- Use the notes you have to flesh out the rest of the character and repeat the process with other characters.
- With the decided characters have class pair up in groups of 3 and create a vignette of how these 3 lives would interact and what scenario they would be in.
- Select the characters that you find would support your story or produce the most dramatic possibility and begin writing a scene with them.

#### Public Observation

- Create a list of characters and then go to a public place with high foot traffic and find a spot where you can people watch without being intrusive.
- Observe the people in the area and pay attention to people who are interesting and seem like they could fit into the world of your story. Look for character traits, physicality, identifiable tattoos, etc. and write them down"

- Once inspired, begin writing a fictional biography about the character. How did they come to be the person you saw in the public space? What is the story behind a limp or tattoo? Create a big event in the character's life and figure out how it shaped them into who they are now.
- Select the characters that you find would support your story or produce the most dramatic possibility and begin writing a scene with them.

#### **Friend, Family Member, or Acquaintance**

- Create a list of characters and then think about people you know in your life who seem as though they could fit into the role of this character.
- Look at the selected people for character traits, physicality, identifiable tattoos, etc. and write them down”
- Once inspired, begin writing a fictional biography about the character incorporating what you know about the actual person and embellishing on details and expanding on areas that are unfamiliar. How did they come to be the person you know? What is the story behind a limp or tattoo? Create a big event in the character's life and figure out how it shaped them into who they are now.
- Select the characters that you find would support your story or produce the most dramatic possibility and begin writing a scene with them.

#### **Your Imagination**

- Create a list of characters you think would be interesting to have in your play based on their relationship to your idea and conflict.
- You do not need any advice for anything else. You are the artist. Use your beautiful imagination and create!
- Get rid of any character that does not directly serve the plot.

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## 1.13: Scene

A scene is a character's attempt to solve a problem. At the beginning of your story you introduce the world of the play and the characters who inhabit it. You then need to establish a normal day for the characters in the world. At the end of the first scene you will need to introduce the major conflict of the play. Every additional scene is a character attempting to solve the problem or conflict and by failing to do so making their plight worse. Each scene should build in intensity and the character's desire to resolve the conflict should grow along with the consequences of failing. By the end of the story the conflict should feel insurmountable and difficult and the character should be consumed with resolving the conflict and solving the problem posed in the first scene.

Scenes vary in length and can be adapted based on the needs of the story. A common length of a scene is usually around 7-10 minutes. While writing, estimate that the actors speaking your text will average about 1 minute per page and so a 10 minute scene would be roughly 10 pages of text. If however, you have a character giving a monologue the speech will take a lot longer and your page count will diminish.

When writing a scene remember to infuse your characters primary need into the conflict of the scene and make the stakes sufficient that the character's need for the objective will pull them through the scene. Intention and obstacle are the name of the game in scene work. Each character in the scene needs to have a strong intention or desire and there needs to be an obstacle in the scene where the characters need to overcome in order to get closer to fulfilling their intention or goal. In overcoming the obstacle they also progress the plot, develop relationships, and increase the stakes of the play. Ask yourself what each character wants in the scene and what each character wants from each other? Then ask yourself what happens if that character doesn't get what they want? And finally why does the character need it now? Make it your goal to have a strong scene where each character's intentions are clear and to have your scene both serve the plot and be able to stand on its own if taken out of context.

### Playwriting Activity 1

- Choose 2 characters you have created and give each a strong intention.
- Write a scene where: Each character needs something from the other but is not allowed to communicate directly what they need. Have them work to achieve their goal and by the end the relationship is strengthened or weakened.

### Playwriting Activity 2

- Choose 2 characters you have created and give each a strong intention.
- Write a scene where: Each character needs something but they encounter an unexpected obstacle that needs to be overcome in order to achieve their intention. Have them work to achieve their goal and a relationship is weakened or strengthened, conflict is furthered, and the scene builds to a climax

### Playwriting Activity 3

- Choose 3 characters you have created and give each a strong intention.
- Write a scene where: Each character needs something from the other but is not allowed to communicate directly what they need, but they encounter an unexpected obstacle that needs to be overcome in order to achieve their intention. Have them work to achieve their goal, furthers the conflict, a character reveals something about his/herself that strengthens/weakens a relationship, and builds to a climax

### Playwriting Activity 4

- Choose 3 characters you have created and give each a strong intention.
- Write a dialogue where one character reveals something about themselves through a monologue.
- Make sure that you answer the following questions for each character before you begin writing: Who wants what? What happens when they don't get it? Why now?

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## 1.14: Crafting the Plot

Every story you tell will be creating a world where you present a problem and over the course of the story you solve it. In the process of solving the problem the hero is transformed and through the character's journey the audience learns an important essential truth. However, in order to tell this story you need to first chart the course of events that will take place so that you can maximize the impact of your narrative.

First begin by establishing your Inciting Incident. Ask yourself "what happens that sets the play in motion?" Then ask yourself "What should be the climax or final event?" Once you have these two items figured out, you will know where your story truly begins and what you are building to. The story of your play is the journey from Inciting Incident to Climax.

Create an outline where you have your Inciting Incident on one end and the Climax on the other. If you are creating a full length play then you will need roughly 7-10 scenes. Scene 1 is where you introduce the world of your play, the main characters, establish a normal day for the characters, and at the end of the scene introduce the conflict with the Inciting Incident. Your final scene is the final confrontation of Hero and Villain and the Denouement or falling action where things return to as normal as possible after the events of the play. All of the scenes between are the events that build in tension and lead to the inevitable climax.

Crafting your plot allows you to sidestep writers block, troubleshoot problems in advance, and build tension throughout your story. When you know what needs to be accomplished in the scene you are able to write to that objective and since you have already established a strong intention for each character, once you set them in the scene they will move toward that objective and the scene will write itself. If you experience problems you can take a break from writing the scene since you already know where the scene ends and you can begin writing a later scene and stay productive.

The Following are 2 possible guides helping you craft your plot.

### Example 1

- Act 1/Scene 1: Exposition, Foreshadowing, Inciting Incident.
  - Establish characters, basic relationships, dreams/goals
  - World of the play: Rules, Givens, Setting
  - Conflict is introduced
  - Inciting incident happens
- Scene 2: Rising action step 1
  - Relationships are further defined
  - New relationships begin to form based out of conflict
  - Conflict is furthered and additional obstacles are introduced
  - Introduction of additional characters
- Scene 3: Rising action step 2
  - Conflict is furthered
  - Relationships continue to develop
  - Protagonist is able to form an idea of how to overcome the obstacle
- Scene 4: Rising Action step 3
  - Stronger relationships begin to get stronger and the weak ones get weaker.
  - At least one obstacle is overcome
  - Conflict is furthered as dark twist is revealed
- Act 2/ Scene 5: Rising Action step 4
  - Relationships continue to develop stronger relationships are formed and weaker ones continue to deteriorate.
  - Protagonist is able to overcome multiple obstacles
  - Conflict is furthered as the Antagonist becomes aware of the threat.
- Scene 6: Rising Action step 5
  - Conflict is furthered as Antagonist introduces additional obstacles
  - Protagonist feels defeated
- Scene 7: Rising Action step 6

- Relationships strengthen through character revelations
- Turning point as protagonist decides to continue fighting
- Scene 8: Climax and Denouement
  - Conflict rises and reaches a climax as Protagonist and Antagonist collide.
  - Conflict is resolved

## Example 2

### Act 1

- Scene 1: Setup/Catalyst
  - Opening Image
  - Set up / Prologue / Exposition
  - Catalyst or Inciting Incident
- Scene 2: Rising Action
  - Debate
  - Decision
  - Fun and Games or New World is introduced
- Scene 3: Rising Action/Fun and Games
  - New Characters are introduced
  - New world explored and obstacle is introduced
  - Stakes raise and conflict is furthered
- Scene 4: Rising Action/ Fun and Games
  - New obstacles are introduced
  - New world is explored
  - Hero becomes aware of potential
- Scene 5: Midpoint
  - An obstacle is overcome or almost overcome
  - Hero unlocks potential
  - Dark turn happens that raises the stakes for the hero

### Intermission

### Act 2

- Scene 1: Bad Guys Close In or Tensions Rise
  - Villain becomes aware of Hero and begins to set additional obstacles
  - Relationships begin to fracture
- Scene 2: All is Lost
  - Hero receives crushing defeat and relationships are torn apart
- Scene 3: Dark night of the Soul
  - Hero contemplates giving up the journey or ending their life
  - Side character counsels Hero and reminds them of the lessons learned throughout the journey and tremendous cost of failure.
  - Hero finds strength in the interaction and from within and decides to confront the villain directly
- Scene 4: Finale
  - Hero and Villain meet in final conflict
  - Climax is reached
- Scene 5: Denouement or Resolution
  - Conflict is resolved and things return to as normal as possible
  - A new normal is established

### Playwriting Activity 1

- Choose a conflict, setting, and characters for your play.
- Draw a line on a sheet of paper that runs from one end of the page to the other. This will be your timeline.
- Choose an inciting incident and climax for your plot and place them at opposite ends of your timeline.
- Follow the examples above and chart a logical progression that leads you from inciting incident to climax maximizing the growth or transformation of your hero character.
- Evaluate whether any events need to shift.
- Separate your events into scenes.
- Begin writing.

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## 1.15: The Process

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Every playwright has a process unique to them and this process will begin to shape how you develop ideas. The process I am going to outline for you is a helpful guide to keep you moving towards completion. Tell your story, and along the way you will find that even though you will have plotted out where you wish to go with the story, it can change and you will find that as the author you discover the play more than create it.

The process of writing a play is hard work and requires a lot of discipline. Sometimes you will feel inspired and the words flow easily from your head to the page and sometimes it will feel like an insurmountable task to complete a simple exchange of dialogue. The audience will never know the difference. Keep writing. If you find that your character has run into a problem that you cannot easily solve, good! Both you and the characters are in the exact same situation and if you do not know how to solve the problem neither will the audience. In those instances, think and troubleshoot. When you have an idea use it and see where it goes. If you find that two scenes are similar then don't be afraid to get rid of one. If you find that along the way the plot needs to shift, then shift it in the outline. Trust yourself and remember that you can always go back.

When you begin writing you will need to start with a concept or idea, if you do not have one then go to the idea store and shop around with the various exercises. Once you have an idea, begin to research materials related to it and expand your knowledge.

Once you feel you are familiar with the subject matter ask yourself what the central message of the play should be. This will guide you, but it can always change along the way. You want to have a reason to write the play and to keep going on hard days. Once you have developed a theme you are ready to begin creating a central conflict. First ask yourself what kind of story you want to tell and what the conflict should be. If the conflict is external and it is a buddy love story, then you can place it in a specific location that will best tell your story.

Once you know what subject you are writing about, have a theme, conflict, story type and setting, you will find that the rest of the ideas start to fall into place. Your next step is to create characters based around the conflict. Once the characters are created and narrowed down to who you would like to be in your play, assign each character you have chosen an archetype to serve as in the story.

When you have assigned characters to archetypes now you know whose story you are telling. Your hero needs to grow the most throughout the play. Don't give your best lines to secondary characters, give them to your lead. It is your hero's story not anyone else's. Your hero serves the plot and theme and your hero is who the audience grows beside. Now that you have the Theme, Conflict, Setting, and Characters decide what your Inciting Incident will be and what you want the climax of the play to be. Once these elements have been selected, create an outline where you craft the plot and structure the events into a logical build that capitalizes on raising tension and connecting you from Inciting Incident to Climax.

Break the plot into scenes and begin writing. Do NOT edit as you write, rather finish the scene and edit afterwards. Complete each scene and make sure that each character is serving the plot, is pursuing their objective, and if a character is failing to do so revise their part or cut them from the show.

When you have completed your play, read it out loud to yourself. This will help you find mistakes that you would not otherwise see while reading it silently to yourself. Your next step is to invite actors to come read your play out loud and to hear how the play flows and see if the story works the way you want it to. See if there are any unnecessary scenes and cut them, see if there are missing elements and add them. Then have another reading.

When you finally feel like it is ready to be staged or if there is interest, give it to a company and see what they do with it. This is the part of the process where you give away control and you can see how your play will be perceived by your audience.

The hardest part of theater is always feeling like your work is not good enough and then having it put on display for the audience to judge. Don't forget that your audience wants to enjoy your play. They got took the night off, got babysitters, and paid to see your story. They walk in giving you their full attention and it is yours to lose. Through this process you will have the highest highs and the experience the lowest lows, but the audience will tell you the truth. Listen to them. Make sure that your work is performed for your target audience and listen. If something is missing, fix it or leave it alone and move on to your next project.

Inevitably there has to be a time where you complete the project and move on. You have more ideas and more stories to tell. Congratulate yourself on accomplishing something extraordinary and start a new project.

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## 1.16: Writing Exercises

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### Kitchen Sink

- Free write where 3 elements decided by the instructor are placed on the board every 5 min and students must incorporate these elements into the scene. Instructor comes up with original scenario and 2 additional items. (i.e. glass breaks/explosion/someone yells)
- The idea is to begin by writing a dialogue between the two characters and to not stop writing for 15 minutes.
- Possible Scenarios
  - Two people meet on a park bench.
  - Two people are stuck in a room and must get out.
  - Two people are on either side of a door.
  - Two people are meeting at a cafe
  - Two people are visiting and a mysterious package arrives.

### Group Exercise

- Bring in an article on current event/picture/special object.
- Choose volunteer and use what they brought in to develop Theme/Conflict.
- Have each member of class write down a character who has a relationship to the conflict and theme. (ie. a plane crash: I am the pilot of the plane that crashed/ I am a single mother on the plane that crashed/ I am the wife of the pilot of the plane that crashed/ I am the owner of the airline that crashed/ etc.
- Have students write their character on a piece of paper and place it somewhere in the room.
- Allow 5 min for students to go around the room and look.
- Have students choose a character that they did not create and improv their bio in front of class, while the rest of the class takes notes on the character. Have them blend elements of their own life into character. Have q and a with character.
- Write a scene where: Conflict is furthered, a character reveals something about his/herself that strengthens/weakens a relationship, and builds to a climax

### Article/Picture/Object

- Bring in an article on current event/picture/special object.
- Using objects brought in: Create theme/conflict/setting
- Establish characters that are related to conflict
- Write a dialogue where character reveals something about themselves through a monologue.

### Art Gallery

- Go to Art gallery
- Write a scene based on a piece of art

### Music

- Choose a piece of music that evokes a strong emotion.
- Write a scene where two characters are on either side of a door and need something from one another.
- Write while listening to the music.

### Special Article/Object brought from home

- Study the object closely.
- Write scene inspired by object.

### Found Object

- Go outside for 10 min and bring in object you found.
- Write scene based on object.
- Present and discuss

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# Index

## D

dialogue

1.11: Dialogue

## S

scene

1.13: Scene

## T

theme

1.5: Theme

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    - [InfoPage](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [Table of Contents](#) - [Undeclared](#)
    - [Licensing](#) - [Undeclared](#)
  - [1: Chapters](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.1: Playwriting](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.2: The Steps of the Writing Process](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.3: The Idea Store](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
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    - [1.6: Conflict](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.7: Types of Story](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.8: Setting](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.9: Character and Story Archetypes](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.10: Plot](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.11: Dialogue](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.12: Creating Characters](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.13: Scene](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.14: Crafting the Plot](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.15: The Process](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
    - [1.16: Writing Exercises](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
  - [Back Matter](#) - [Undeclared](#)
    - [Index](#) - [Undeclared](#)
    - [Glossary](#) - [CC BY 4.0](#)
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